

Section one

Understand the Process

CHAPTER 1

How to Hire Top Talent

by Ryan Renteria

All managers need a few essential skills to successfully lead and make an impact in their organization. Communication, decision-making, empathy, and adaptability are some of the capabilities most widely researched and written about in the business world. There is one skill, however, that's often less discussed—learning how to hire top talent.

In my 22 years of experience on Wall Street, in professional sports, and most recently as an executive coach, I've seen the positive impact a great hiring strategy can have on a manager's career. While you may not always have the power to choose your team, learning how to spot and appeal to high-performing candidates can fundamentally impact your trajectory.

What do I mean by top talent? Stellar hard skills—the technical skills needed to perform a specific role—are table stakes. You should also be looking for a few vital soft skills:

- **Intrinsic motivation:** Top talent means people who are motivated by their own desire to learn and grow. Their behavior or past experiences demonstrate curiosity, autonomy, and resourcefulness in solving problems or overcoming challenging work situations.
- **Perseverance:** A top job candidate should display open-mindedness and adaptability. These are people who've shown they can navigate uncertainty and unexpected roadblocks.
- **Reliability:** Top talent are reliable—people with strong organizational skills who pay attention to detail. They meet deadlines. You can trust them to get things right and deliver quality work.

A team of people who possess these qualities can be trusted to execute tasks on time and to a high standard. This allows you to delegate tasks and assign projects that are relevant to their individual areas of expertise. This creates a win-win situation for everyone. It gives your direct reports more opportunities to take on visible work that will help them grow and potentially introduce them to powerful stakeholders throughout the company. It also creates space for you to engage in bigger-picture, strategic thinking about your organization's business goals and how your team can help them come to fruition. You'll have more time to develop strategic team goals, improve on processes that may be slowing you down, and produce results.

Moreover, a strong and reliable team creates fewer fires for you to put out. This leaves you less susceptible to the burnout that harms leadership careers, personal lives, and mental health.

Whether you're new to hiring or looking for a quick refresher because it's been a while since you've sat on this side of the table, here are the most important steps to increase your odds of making a great hire.

Develop a Strong Hiring Process

I once worked with a client who had a meticulous hiring process and a reliable team; that is, until Brad (not his real name) joined the company. One of my client's team members—let's call him Christopher—slipped up during the interview process. When Christopher interviewed Brad, he fell in love with his background and qualifications. Worried that another company would snatch him up, Christopher offered Brad the job just a few days after the person he was replacing announced his retirement. In the end, Brad struggled to meet the expectations of the role. Because he wasn't thoroughly vetted, neither Brad nor the company were set up for success.

You can avoid critical mistakes like Christopher's by mastering three parts of a hiring process:

1. *Write a strong job description*

The first step to landing a talented candidate is to sell them with an incredible first impression. This starts with the job description. If you're able to weigh in on this aspect of the application, ask yourself the following questions: Why would your company be the right one for your ideal candidate? How is your company different from the other options it may be considering?

In the description itself, focus on the following areas:

Start by describing your company's purpose

What are you trying to achieve in the marketplace? Why should anyone care? How is your culture different from others out there? A good match for the role should read the job description and think, "Wow, this company really aligns with my values and goals." If the values of the new company were more aligned with theirs, 87% of Gen Z would switch jobs.¹ Moreover, if you hire people who share your organization's values, they'll be more likely to feel engaged in their role.

Detail their tasks and how they connect to the goals you just described

Ninety-one percent of people consider quitting a job within the first month if it doesn't match their expectations.² This is reason enough to be crystal clear about what you expect. Otherwise, you'll waste time and money by losing a talented hire shortly after they join.

To ensure that candidates understand how their role and responsibilities contribute to the larger mission, include a few sentences that describe how every task—even potential grunt work—has meaning behind it. For example, if one task is taking notes during team meetings, you could add an explanation like "to ensure the group stays aligned and can execute projects more efficiently."

Lay out the skills required to execute those outcomes

Don't forget to describe the specific competencies you're looking for. Which technical skills are you seeking? Which soft skills do you feel are critical to your group's success? You need to be clear about these to find candidates who can meet the requirements of the role—and deliver.

2. *Nail the interview process*

The next step to hiring top talent is getting the interview process right. In my experience, this requires three things: an organized and unbiased evaluation process, unique questions, and sample assignments.

Before the interviews, create a straightforward evaluation system

I recommend having a rubric that clearly defines each qualification you're looking for and a scoring system the hiring committee can use to measure the candidates in each area (see [chapter 21](#) for a sample). You will likely be measuring candidates on a combination of soft skills like intrinsic motivation, problem-solving, adaptability, organization, and attention to detail as well as the technical skills needed to carry out the responsibilities of the role.

Assign a weight of importance to each qualification. This will help you calculate the total score for each candidate after every round of interviews. That score won't be the sole determinant of who you hire. But it will give you a process to quantify their strengths and weaknesses as seen by several teammates and help you counter the biases that show up during typical hiring decision discussions.

During the interview, ask unique questions to get authentic, unplanned responses

Here are a few favorites I've developed or learned from smart interviewers and used over the years.

- "I'll be asking candidates who advance to future rounds to provide several references, like former bosses and other people who can speak to their performance. Is that OK with you?" This revealing question can save you from a bad hire. Pay attention to body language and see who gets uncomfortable. Top talent with nothing to hide will be thrilled you're doing this diligence.
- "What are the biggest mistakes you think our company is currently making? What would you do differently?" You're testing their critical thinking, level of detailed research on your company, and confidence to speak up and challenge you.
- "Tell me about a time you disagreed with the majority of your team members. Which counterarguments altered your thinking? What would it have taken for you to have completely changed your view?" You're analyzing how open-minded they are and how willing they are to adapt or engage in high-candor debate.
- "What do you read in your spare time to sharpen your knowledge?" You're looking for signals of intellectual curiosity, a growth mindset, and the motivation to become more well-rounded.
- "If you join our team and it doesn't work out, what is the most likely reason why?" This is a creative way to tease out a potential deal breaker or weakness.

Give them a sample assignment to complete by a deadline

Choose an assignment related to the tasks they would be tackling or the problems they would be solving in the actual role, and provide them with clear, specific instructions.³ The assignment shouldn't be too large of an ask, and it should be ethical—this is not an opportunity to get free work. Allow them to work on the assignment on their own time (not during the actual interview).

For example, when I was an institutional investor, I interviewed many analysts for my team. I would assign them a stock and ask them to conduct a full research process on the company. They had to build a financial forecast, assess the upsides and downsides of investing, and communicate their recommendation succinctly.

Sample assignments like these help you see if the candidate has the hard skills needed to succeed in the role and give you a sneak peek into the quality of their work. The result doesn't need to be perfect—you're really testing for attention to detail, punctuality, and high potential for learning and improvement.

3. *Make the most of reference checks*

Don't underestimate the value of reference checks—it's an opportunity to dig deeper and get the whole picture of a candidate. At the same time, because this step is often carried out by human resources, you may have to be a bit more proactive about being involved. For example, you can email your HR representative to let them know you want to gather more information on your top candidates and that speaking to their references will be essential to your final decision. If you receive any pushback, ask if you can submit a few specific questions you'd like them to ask while vetting your candidates.

Here are two strategies that can help you (or your HR team) make the most of this final step.

Put references at ease

Assure references that they have 100% confidentiality, and no comments will ever be traceable back to them. Emphasize that this reference call is one of dozens of reasons the candidate may or may not get the job. These assurances should make references more open.

Ask questions that ensure you don't get boilerplate responses

Below are the most effective reference questions I've developed or acquired from great hirers and used over time.

- “I want to balance the strengths and weaknesses of my team members. What are [name's] strengths and weaknesses, and in your experience, what kind of qualities help balance them out?” Or “What kind of teammates do they collaborate best with?”
- “How reliable and organized is [name] when it comes to getting their work done on time and accurately?”
- “When [name] disagrees with you or another person, how open-minded are they about considering another viewpoint, compromising, or adapting their view?”
- “On a scale of 1 to 10, what is your level of endorsement and why?”

When the time comes for you to make your next hire, a quick review of these essentials will position you for success.

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Adapted from “New Leaders, Here’s How to Hire a Top Talent” on hbr.org, January 2, 2024.

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CHAPTER 2

Future-Focused Recruiting Strategies

An interview with Lauren Smith by Curt Nickisch

Remember when tech startups used to show off their catered lunches, onsite yoga instructors, and ultra-cool workspaces? Those are not such big selling points today. More people want to work remotely. It's just one of many ways that the pandemic significantly changed recruiting and hiring.

To better understand these forces, the advisory firm Gartner surveyed 3,000 job candidates and more than 3,500 hiring managers. The research details some of these hiring trends and points to ways that leaders can more effectively shape their workforces.

HBR: I have to admit, I was surprised at what your research found—that the pandemic didn't really disrupt recruiting and hiring as much as it accelerated trends that were already there. How is that the case?

SMITH: Three big shifts have been accelerated by the pandemic, but they definitely began before it. The first is the evolution of skills. The pace at which we work is changing, making it challenging for us to accurately define jobs. This became more universal as many organizations shifted to virtual or hybrid work, or needed to develop new types of automation.

The second big shift is the dispersion of skills beyond traditional talent pools, meaning that where we have found talent in the past isn't necessarily the best place to find it now. And the third is that candidates' expectations for their work have changed, requiring organizations to rethink how they're branding jobs and how they sell them in the labor market.

Let's start with that second one. Things have definitely changed.

They have. One of the biggest reasons is the normalization of remote work. Many organizations are no longer tied to sourcing candidates from where we've successfully found talent before and this opens up talent pools in a way that's game changing.

And of course, this also changes the calculation for candidates. Remote opportunities mean they can apply for jobs anywhere that their skills match.

What have you heard from managers looking to hire for an opening on their team? How are they experiencing this?

There was a lot of skepticism, especially for those managers who had not had virtual or remote direct reports before: "Will they be as productive?" "Can we collaborate virtually?" There's been a fair amount of surprise that individuals' ability to actually get their work done was a lot better than anticipated.

We've always thought about where people will sit when they come into a job. As if the physical space frames what that person should or shouldn't be doing. And when you're working remotely, organizations are liberated from that.

Absolutely. And it comes down to that first shift that I mentioned around the evolution of skills because so much of what managers traditionally do when hiring is look backward to the employee who has left the position. They create a job description like “I would like that past individual, plus those three other qualifications”—in essence, a purple unicorn that's very challenging for recruiters to find.

The realities of remote work and the evolution of skills means that managers can stop thinking about who they would like to hire and instead focus on the work they need done. This shift from looking at openings as an opportunity to hire to an opportunity to make a skills decision is really liberating.

Do you have a good example of an organization implementing that, and how it worked out for them?

One of the organizations we spoke with had a very interesting practice. Every time a critical role opened up, instead of going through the traditional requisition process of asking a manager to conduct the hire, the company made it a team activity. It asked the team to define the role—not what was needed in the past, but what's needed moving forward.

Not only did the team have a better understanding of the job as it was evolving on a daily basis and what was needed in terms of the interaction onsite, but they could also identify the outdated parts of the job description. So they were able to define the role in a different way.

Let's talk about the third trend your research uncovered—that candidates are increasingly selective about employers. I think that changes in recent years to the power dynamics of hiring and getting hired are really interesting. What did you see there?

Candidates increasingly expect companies to offer them not only competitive compensation and benefits, but also a compelling employee experience. People who worked remotely during lockdown got used to designing their own work experience—fitting their job into their life. Now candidates are less likely to want to give up this autonomy even if they are returning to an in-person work environment.

So we're hearing from organizations that to attract top candidates, they need to offer a more humanized deal focusing on candidates as people, not just workers. Now of course that doesn't mean you give candidates everything they want, but you do need to understand where they're coming from to make sure that you're not losing talent to competitors.

In your research, you said that companies need to address “employment value proposition.”

That's right. An employment value proposition is the attributes that we offer as an organization that's going to be most attractive to candidates. And depending on the job, that's going to look very different. For some roles in knowledge work, more candidates expect flexibility. They expect a feeling of autonomy. This may mean enabling them to continue to design their work around life.

For others jobs, where such autonomy is not possible, you still need to think about how you're going to enable candidates or employees to better fit their work into their life. Scheduling flexibility is a great way.

What else are employers building into their employment value proposition?

One of the other big trends is what we've come to think of as deeper connections—understanding not just employees, but also their families and community. In lockdown, employees were working from home with small children nearby or other visible family obligations. Organizations need to continue to understand not just what their employees want, but what the people around them need.

We've seen organizations think about this in a couple of ways, whether it be opening up development opportunities to an employee's family or providing specific benefits for parents with children. So that's going to be another piece that's going to continue to evolve.

Your research pointed out that a lot of workers have taken the opportunity with their autonomy and their ability to time-shift their work to do a lot of professional development on their own, and that employers need to be aware of that.

That's right. In fact, in a survey that we ran before the pandemic, 43% of candidates said they were self-taught in one or more of the required skills for their job. So we know this has been happening for a while, but since the pandemic, there's been a boom in online learning as employees are looking to try things out beyond their current role or position themselves to be more marketable in this new environment.

It's important for organizations scanning their internal labor market to ask their employees about the skills that they have today as well as some of the skills they're hoping to build or that they're working on.

At the same time, companies need to be beefing up their ability to recruit outside of their traditional talent pools. What are some of the ways they're successfully doing that?

One of the biggest reasons that there's a lot of momentum around looking beyond traditional talent pools is that organizations are focused on advancing the diversity of their workforce. It's important to audit the current hiring process to identify where diverse candidates may be being excluded. This can be done by looking at data of recent candidates, going through the process, or creating journey maps of different candidate profiles to understand where there may be challenges.

For example, one head of recruiting I spoke with mentioned that internal talent is being excluded at pre-application because they weren't aware of existing opportunities. We've also seen examples of self-taught talent being excluded in screening because of educational requirements listed on a job description.

Really understanding where we are is important because just looking for talent in nontraditional talent pools and putting them into our existing process is not going to get the outcomes we want. For example, one hiring manager we spoke with had an interesting approach to make sure that they were looking at candidate potential over candidate credentials. It's easy to assume that great credentials or qualifications make a great candidate. But this manager looked at the skills that they needed to make sure that a candidate can grow with them over time. They landed on things like curiosity, agility, and teamwork and focused on evaluating candidates against those skills—not whether they had specific industry experience or went to one of the six schools the company traditionally recruited from.

What you're outlining makes a lot of sense. It also sounds hard, especially when companies are recruiting and hiring in a new way. HR and hiring managers haven't always been in sync. HR's often seen as a siloed part of the organization.

Absolutely. Managers who are hiring for an opening on their team and recruiting and HR leaders need to recognize that we're all on the same team looking to bring in the best talent that can move our organizations forward.

By focusing on the skills that we need to build the workforce of the future, we'll avoid just replacing the workforce we had, or getting caught in the weeds around a specific job description, or hiring a candidate because the manager went to a similar university. We need to bring the conversation back to "What do we need as an organization?" "How are we going to partner together to bring those skills in?"

I always say that HR shouldn't think of hiring as an HR activity, as a business mandate. Thinking about a manager's role around talent, not just about developing and coaching, but also their role in hiring—"How do we work together to bring in the next-generation workforce?"—makes a big difference as you think about bringing managers and HR together.

If you're a manager, what are a few things you can do the next time you look to hire somebody to really have impact?

The most important thing to do is to not just dust off the old job description when someone leaves your team. The first thing to do is document the emerging, expiring, and evolving skills associated with this role.

Emerging skills are the new things that you're going to need as the business or the nature of the team is changing. Expiring skills are those that maybe the last person had that are not as important anymore. And evolving skills is probably the most important piece. We can all think about examples of this, like learning to onboard a new team member virtually, even if you've onboarded lots of people previously.

And if a manager is able to map out the emerging, expiring, and evolving skills their team needs and bring that into a conversation with the recruiter, it's going to better position everyone to focus on *what* we're looking for, not *who* we're looking for.

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CHAPTER 3

Forty Ideas to Shake Up Your Hiring Process

by Joseph Fuller, Nithya Vaduganathan, Allison Bailey, and Manjari Raman

Despite challenging economic conditions, companies find it difficult to attract and retain the right talent. That's one of the takeaways from a US Bureau of Labor Statistics report, which showed that job vacancies remain above 10 million as of November 2022.¹ We've confirmed that trend in our own work: when we surveyed 800 senior business leaders in August 2022, more than 95% of them told us that hiring and retaining talent was one of their top three priorities as they strive to deliver on their strategies. However, those needs are not constrained to the short term: More than two-thirds of the leaders we surveyed reported that filling positions for lower- and higher-wage workers is critical for their organization's ability to compete, both in the next 12 to 18 months and in the next three to five years.

But business leaders are doing very little that's innovative to tackle the talent challenge. When it comes to higher-wage workers, they're relying primarily on two basic strategies: increasing compensation (a fairly obvious approach) and implementing remote/hybrid work models. They're doing even less for lower-wage workers: In our survey, fewer than half of respondents reported using basic levers, such as health care benefits and compensation increases, to attract and retain these workers.

Much of this is due to a lack of awareness of innovative talent practices. Many of the leaders we surveyed simply did not know what other options were available. This, they recognized, was a problem: Fewer than 20% of them reported that their organizations had very mature talent strategies.

So how can you enable more talent innovation and measure its impact? Based on our survey findings, organizations need to use a more expansive portfolio of practices to strengthen their ability to recruit and retain talent. To help, we've identified nearly 40 strategies, which we've organized into seven categories that either strengthen the hiring process or help enhance a company's offer. Some of these practices are familiar but underutilized, and others are newer and more innovative.

Strengthening the Hiring Process

Hiring campaign and selection

Many companies rely on traditional recruiting strategies to identify candidates who fulfill a long list of requirements. Finding candidates who tick off every box on the list is not easy—and those few who do are often actually not the right people for the job. By embracing more expansive hiring and selection processes, companies can do a better job of finding the talent that's right for them. Here are some innovative practices to consider:

- Figure out what work *really* needs to get done, then rewrite job descriptions to focus on the skills and specs that matter the most for that work, instead of relying on generic education or experience requirements.
- Seek candidates who match 70% to 80% of the most critical skills for the role—and develop learning curricula to equip them with the remainder.
- Offer “micro-internships” (short-term paid projects) or apprenticeships that reach new candidate pools and allow employers and candidates to assess fit before committing to a full-time hire.
- Host open hackathons to assess talent and facilitate the hiring of candidates in batches.
- Consider candidates simultaneously for multiple open roles if they have a high number of overlapping skills.
- Leverage tech- and AI-based talent assessments to screen for technical or interpersonal skills.
- Employ inclusive, gender-neutral language in job descriptions to attract more diverse candidates.

Talent sourcing

When competition for top talent is fierce, as it is today, you need to broaden your methods of sourcing candidates. Here are some practices to consider:

- Expand internal talent mobility (e.g., lateral job transfers, internal gig work) by drawing on a foundation of skills and aspirations as a basis for mobility and supporting retention.
- Embrace on-demand and gig platforms to increase labor force flexibility (even for higher-wage workers), accelerate time-to-market, and enable innovation.
- Work to attract alumni with valuable institutional knowledge back to your organization.
- Build an internal list of previously high-performing employees who might be candidates to reengage for future roles.

- Tap into “hidden” populations, including retired, neurodiverse, and previously incarcerated workers.
- Acquire companies with top talent—or enter into agreements to borrow and share talent with other companies.

Channel strategy

Companies that integrate new and innovative channels into their talent strategy can better recruit critical, in-demand talent for years to come. Consider expanding your repertoire to include the following techniques:

- Deploy talent from Hire-Train-Deploy (HTD) partners who source high-potential candidates and equip them with the relevant skills for your needs.
- Use digital platforms to do more programmatic and personalized recruiting (including leveraging QR codes, text messaging).
- Partner with educational and community institutions, including job centers and community colleges, to offer tailored curriculum and term-time work experiences to build a talent pipeline with relevant skills.
- Embrace new ways of identifying talent on social media platforms (such as layoff lists and LinkedIn posts).
- Develop and market a more effective referral program, particularly for in-demand roles.

Enhancing the Offer

Compensation and benefits

Are you one of the many employers raising salaries to compete for talent? Half of the 800+ respondents in our survey reported increasing compensation for their employees, and nearly 75% of employers cite the talent shortage as the main driver for salary budget increases.² But there are other ways to strengthen your compensation and benefits package. Try some of these practices to get started:

- Provide creative benefits, such as caregiver support programs, childcare services, and wellness perks.
- Segment and develop tailored benefits for hard-to-fill talent populations.

- Provide incentives, such as higher bonuses during peak hours and step-ups on promotion, especially for lower-wage workers.
- Guarantee health care benefits and appropriate sick time for your full workforce.
- Reduce volatility by ensuring stable and predictable pay, particularly for lower-wage workers.

Work Design

Job flexibility has skyrocketed in importance since the onset of the pandemic, with some employees valuing flexibility even more than a 10% pay raise. Rethinking work design can not only better attract and retain workers but can also increase productivity and focus worker capacity on the highest-value tasks. Get started redesigning work with the following strategies:

- Break work into its components to assign responsibilities more clearly across a team or to freelance workers, and improve your approach to sourcing.
- Deploy talent more dynamically by creating skills-based talent pools that can be assigned to the most critical priorities on demand.
- Use creative scheduling and shift redesign to allow lower-wage workers to move or switch shifts more flexibly while still providing adequate coverage.
- Experiment with different flex models, including compressed workweeks, sharing jobs among multiple part-time employees, and/or scheduling split shifts to cover “rush hours.”
- Redesign work by eliminating, reassigning, or automating less-critical responsibilities.
- Embed technology that improves ease of work, including language assistance and tools to accommodate older workers.

Career development

Providing opportunities for your employees to take on stretch assignments can help you not only develop but also retain your employees. According to the Pew Research Center, more than 60% of US employees cited a lack of career-advancement opportunities as a leading reason for leaving their jobs.³ To expand your organization’s portfolio of career-advancement opportunities, consider adding some of these innovative practices:

- Provide education benefits linked to individualized skill development plans (for example, tuition reimbursement).

- Build targeted learning and development programs to support onboarding, upskilling, and reskilling across both hard and soft skills.
- Design mentorship and sponsorship programs and peer-to-peer coaching systems.
- Upskill managers to be better people leaders and increase manager accountability for team development.

Culture

Companies need a compelling culture to maximize the engagement, productivity, and retention of their existing workforces. In recent years, company culture has become the most important driver of job satisfaction, with culture being 10 times more predictive of employee retention than compensation.⁴ Here are some innovative practices to help build a meaningful culture:

- Embed company purpose, strategy, and values in your operating and performance practices and feedback process, and train your leaders to become culture champions.
- Set up robust onboarding programs that build affiliation and mentorship into the process.
- Create opportunities and free up as much as 10% to 20% of capacity for passion projects.
- Boost affiliation by developing interest groups and communities of practice.
- Take pulse checks on employee sentiment to highlight opportunities for improvement in near real time.
- Develop clear two-way communication channels for employee input and engagement.

The best talent strategy for your organization involves finding the right portfolio of practices that meet your needs and investing appropriately in their implementation, even during uncertain economic conditions. Many companies across industries have recognized how critical talent is to business success and have kickstarted their innovation journeys based on their target employee needs. For example, IBM removed degree requirements from 50% of their U.S. job postings to widen their talent pools, Walmart provides frontline associates with fully funded college tuition and accelerated career paths after graduation, and some law firms have introduced concierge services to support aging family members.⁵

While you don't have to do everything on our list to have a successful talent strategy, you should identify where you can do more to better compete for talent. Take stock of what your organization is already doing, then thoughtfully assess where there are gaps in your talent strategy and how our suggestions can be helpful. Keep in mind that you may need to tailor your talent strategies to different

employee segments within your company. By experimenting with new innovations and putting the right feedback systems in place, you can develop a sustainable strategy that can help you create lasting talent advantage.

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CHAPTER 4

Imagine a Better Hiring Process

by Alex Haimann

Shortly after we started hiring for our business, we recognized how deeply flawed traditional interview processes are. At the time, we had a goal of growing our CRM software company from six to 18 employees. Our objectives were simple: Find talented people to contribute to our culture, generate great work, and stay with us for the long term. We decided to focus on optimizing our interview process rather than relying on outdated behavioral questions.

Think of the classic prompts: *What are your greatest strengths and weaknesses? Tell me about a time you overcame a challenge at work.*

The standard interview is a tradition of sorts that has been passed down from one generation to another. But, as we discovered through our own missteps, it is unreliable.¹ Behavioral questions might be useful for testing someone's ability to relay biographical information. However, unless storytelling or some equivalent skill is a requirement of the position being filled, they often fail to reveal sufficient information about a candidate's competencies.

You don't need outside consultants or a robust HR function to hire like a pro. Through trial and error, my team and I have used our own experiences, as well as the most recent research available, to create a process that immerses job candidates in unconventional scenarios to gather the most useful insights about their critical-thinking abilities, tech savviness, and interpersonal skills.

Since deployment, we have seen improvements both in the quality of our hires and what they bring to the company. As a result, our retention has improved significantly. In the past seven years, we've had only four full-time employees leave—two for grad school and two for jobs outside of our industry.

Today, we believe that what worked for us can work for other companies too, saving your organization both time and money by finding the right people for the right roles.

This is the process that works for us; let some of the ideas inspire you to adopt or adapt for your own organization and culture.

Part 1: Questions

First, it's important to note that our process varies. We aim to structure our interviews around the skills we're looking for from each candidate and give them the opportunity to demonstrate those skills. Because no two candidates are the same, naturally, neither are two interviews.

Prior to *all* of our interviews, we share the questions we'll be asking with candidates. We ask these questions during the conversational portion of the interview, which comes first and takes 45 to 90 minutes. We're intentionally flexible with time here to allow for whatever subsequent discussions may arise.

Typically, our questions are broken down into three categories:

1. To test for **preparation**, we ask questions that are easy to research. For example, “Can you tell us what you know about our company?” is something that a quick Google search could answer.
2. To test for **critical thinking and tech savviness**, we ask open-ended questions designed to start a conversation and spark creativity in the candidate. For example, we often ask engineering candidates how they would design an app to accomplish a certain task (view pictures of animals, for instance). We ask customer service or salesperson candidates to choose a piece of software they are familiar with and demo it. For a video interview, we’d give the candidate rights to share and ask them to take over and demonstrate the product. During an in-office interview, we would ask the candidate to control the mouse and keyboard to demo the software on a large monitor while we watch.
3. To test for **listening and communication skills**, we format some questions as directions. This gives candidates a clear idea of what we want from them, while at the same time allowing us to see whether they can deliver. For example, to measure a candidate’s ability to communicate effectively, we might say: “Teach us about one of your passions, something that you know a lot about or consider yourself to be a nominal expert in—and teach us as if we know nothing about it.”

Many of our questions in categories 2 and 3 allow candidates to pick the topics of discussion themselves, as opposed to us thrusting ideas on them. We aspire to stimulate a discussion that they (hopefully) want to engage in. If candidates choose topics they don’t know much about or aren’t able to explain, despite having time to prepare beforehand, it shows us that they didn’t care enough about the interview or the position to put in the time. Essentially, we want our hires to have the ability to think ahead and draw on real knowledge and experience in high-pressure situations. What we don’t want is to hire people simply because they have a knack for saying what they think we want to hear.

Video interviews help us measure online communication skills. We can determine a candidate’s tech savviness with programs like Zoom, as well as how they present themselves over video—an important skill, as this is how many members of our team interact with prospects, customers, and other employees.

Part 2: Technical Skills

After the question portion of the interview, we schedule a 45- to 90-minute chat between the candidate and a team member who is an expert in their field, followed by a short exercise to test their collaboration skills.

During the chat, our team members typically ask candidates role-specific questions to help us gauge whether they have a genuine interest in the work they’d be doing. With customer service positions, for example, we ask candidates whether they think helping people is rewarding, whether they like talking on the phone, and so on. Depending on the candidate and the flow of that interview, we might also ask less direct, general questions about their interests and what work they find most rewarding. If our hires love the work they are doing, we’ve found, they are more likely to stay for the long term.

For the exercise portion of this stage, we aim to create scenarios that will allow us to see candidates' skills in action and evaluate how well they collaborate with other employees. This time also gives the candidate an opportunity to experience what it would be like to work on a specific team. For instance, we may ask an engineering candidate to participate in pair programming—a technique in which two developers work together on a problem. While pair programming is a common practice in many coding job interviews, we've incorporated similar team exercises into the interviews for all of our roles.

As with part one of the interview, we let candidates know beforehand which topics will be covered in the technical portion, as it puts the onus on them to come prepared. Videoconferencing technology that incorporates elements like screen-sharing and tools designed specifically for remote code interviews, such as CodeBunk, can be helpful in conducting these exercises virtually.

Part 3: Writing Samples

Many companies collect writing samples from candidates before or after an initial interview. But we believe it is more beneficial to govern this process more closely because it gives us insight into the quality of a candidate's writing without any outside assistance. We want to know that all our hires will be able to communicate clearly in writing without extensive editing and sometimes under time pressure. Though we can't ensure that people aren't seeking outside assistance (such as AI), our process still gives us a good idea of their writing and communication skills.

The assignment we give is specific to the role each candidate is applying for. For example, we give customer service candidates a sample email from a hypothetical angry client, as well as an example email response that reflects our ideal company voice. We ask that they mimic the company voice and write up a client response email of their own. We also expect them to ask as many questions as possible beforehand—and take notes. We don't specify the length of response, but the example gives them a good idea of our expectations.

In the office, we typically give candidates 30 to 45 minutes in a quiet room to complete the writing assignment. Virtually, we would schedule a break in our video call to give them 30 to 45 minutes to complete the assignment. After they've finished, we would resume the interview online as we review the assignment and ask why they chose certain phrasing or structures in their response. When we review the sample, we look at whether they can think critically about composition and voice and demonstrate thoughtfulness overall.

Part 4: Games

We want to know how candidates will interact with their prospective colleagues on a day-to-day basis. But instead of making assumptions based on their answers to interview questions—like “How would your coworkers describe you?” or “What role do you tend to play on a team?”—our process allows us to observe their actual interactions.

In the office, we design peer interactions around board games that challenge players to work together toward a goal, as opposed to games that pit players against one another in a zero-sum scenario. Virtually, we would go with a game, such as Codenames, that's easier to play in a remote setting, but still allows for that key element of collaboration. The goal is twofold: Learn about how the candidate interacts with team members *and* show them that this will be a fun place to work.

Because candidates interact with numerous employees throughout our interview process, many of whom don't share their backgrounds or interests, we find team members who might have more in common with them for this portion of the interview. While it's important for us to make sure the candidate can engage with a diverse group of our employees, during this time specifically, we want them to feel comfortable, conversational, and included.

If our current team is made up of individuals over the age of 45, for instance, and we're interviewing a recent college graduate, we don't necessarily look for the youngest person in the office to

include in this step. Instead, we might look to include the newest, least experienced members of our team, regardless of age, to help the candidate feel more comfortable and less intimidated by experienced employees.

The outcome of the game isn't important. We're looking for signs of a good cultural fit over the course of the three to four hours the players are together. For us, that means candidates are thoughtful, engaging, curious, and make a visible effort to enjoy the experience (even if they are faking it). These attributes aren't role-specific; they're qualities we value as a company.

Quantify What's Working and What's Not

The four pillars above require regular iteration and experimentation. After each round of hiring, we sit down to evaluate the success of our process by looking at a couple of different factors. One of these is how often each pillar swayed our decision. Were we able to make more confident choices using these steps? If so, we take that as validation that the process is working. If not, we take a deeper look at what's not working and how we can fix it.

The most important factor we use to evaluate the success of our process, though, is the quality of our hires. A couple of years ago, when we realized we had hired many interns who were perfectly capable of doing their work but weren't actually interested in the work itself, we knew we had a quality problem to address. Some interns told us during exit interviews that they were just using the internship as a stepping-stone for their next destination, and some declined full-time job offers from us.

That's when we began drafting up more role-specific questions to ask candidates during the technical portion of the interview. Only then did we see our retention grow stronger.

Our post-interview evaluation is another element of the process we had to adjust. Initially, staff members talked to each other about the candidate throughout the interview day (without the candidate present) and compared experiences. But we found this created bias and other conflicts throughout the interview itself.

Now we forbid employees to talk with anyone about the candidate until after the interview is completed. Once it is, everyone who participated completes a survey with feedback about the various areas we assessed. After everyone has filled out the survey, we allow open discussion.

It may be tempting for some leaders to simply accept that hiring is not a perfect science and use that as an excuse to stick with the same outdated interview process corporations have relied on for decades. But today it's safe to say that most businesses can't afford to take a chance on bad hires. We think it's possible to design an interview process that provides a clear assessment of a candidate's skills, aptitude, and potential for culture fit. Our four pillars can be used as a framework for those who wish to do so.

Alex Haimann is a partner and the head of business development at Less Annoying CRM, a simple CRM built from the ground up for small businesses. Over 10,000 small businesses worldwide use LACRM to manage contacts, track leads, and stay on top of follow-ups. LACRM continues to grow by engaging customers and finding new opportunities for mutually beneficial partnerships.

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NOTES

1. Laszlo Bock, "Here's Google's Secret to Hiring the Best People," *Wired*, April 7, 2015, <https://www.wired.com/2015/04/hire-like-google/>.

CHAPTER 5

Six Critical Ways HR Assists with Recruiting and Hiring

by Roxanne Calder

“Hiring talent” rarely appears at the top of a manager’s job description or is even included as a required competency. Maybe that’s because it’s an “assumed skill” that one acquires via experience and exposure at a certain career stage or as a task to delegate to HR (“Put in a call to HR and leave it with them!”) or outsource to a recruiter. But that’s not how it works. As a recruiter with over two decades of experience, I know that successful recruitment requires effective collaboration between HR and hiring managers.

It’s not always easy working with functional teams—people you collaborate with only on occasion. When it comes to HR, it can feel almost personal. How can you trust that they understand the role you’re trying to fill? What if they send the wrong people (or no one at all!)? To hire great people for your team, you must establish and maintain a strong relationship with HR. You’ll need to draw on your collaboration skills and work together to understand each other’s priorities, responsibilities, skill sets, and communication styles and preferences. Keeping an open mind, listening actively, and communicating frequently and consistently will be key to a successful partnership.

Though the ways of working will vary from company to company, most HR teams act as a guide through the recruiting and hiring process, advising on best practices at each stage. HR can be very hands-on, sitting in on all interviews and participating in candidate evaluations, or very hands-off, providing policies and advice and leaving you to it.

While every organization has its own process and culture, here’s the high-level view of how to build an effective partnership with HR to identify, evaluate, and add great people to your team.

Lay the Groundwork

The recruitment process isn’t static. It can involve many people, a lot of moving parts, changing minds and differing opinions, and new information entering the fray. The better you partner with HR to prepare *before* posting the job, the more agile and confident you can be in responding to questions throughout the process and the better you’ll be able to deliver a compelling offer and speedy contract when you’ve made your final selection.

Obtain approval

The first step you’ll take with HR is to secure approval of the job requisition. Many companies require authorization before recruitment can start (this is usually due to budgeting and headcount restrictions, especially during more challenging economic times). Your HR department can advise you on your company’s approval process: whether it requires board, managing director, or CEO-level sign-off, even

if the role is a replacement. Sign-off may take one day or two weeks—even months—and there's a chance that it can be refused altogether. Make sure you've got the needed approval before you start meeting with candidates. Generating a contract and final offer letter takes time, and if you have to backtrack for approval at the end of the process, you run the real risk of losing talent—not to mention damage to your company's reputation and your personal brand.

Understand the full package

Once you have approval to hire, you'll work with HR to understand the total remuneration package. This includes the salary range, benefits, and growth opportunities. Knowing the numbers—including the maximum level you're able to offer—will save you time and avoid having to reopen the approval process. Your HR partner can help you get a strong handle on the benefits your company offers, as well as any perks, and how they translate to dollars. If you're a nonprofit and have salary tax concessions, work to understand what this means in terms of earnings.

You'll also want to review with HR all critical policies, such as working from home, remote work, well-being, parental leave, and so on. If at any stage in the process, your candidate asks a question about any of these matters—including salary—a confident, well-articulated response portrays professionalism and confidence, and goes a long way to establishing trust.

Conduct market research

Beyond your own organization, you'll want to step back to look at the context of the wider market. Failure to understand the employment landscape can lead to losing out on great candidates or making hiring mistakes. If HR hasn't provided you with market and industry information about similar roles, they can help you find it. Once you know the remuneration package you can offer, look at job boards and salary guides or reach out to expert recruiters to check that it is aligned with the market. Taking the existing salary of the incumbent and assuming it's at the right level is easy but won't always be accurate if you haven't recruited for the role in a while (even within the last 12 months).

If, after comparing the salary package with the market, you find that what you're offering isn't competitive, you may need a backup plan. Consider what else you can incorporate into the offer to make it more attractive. Look to cultural elements and unique selling points such as summer hours or professional development opportunities. Additionally, revisit the job description. Are there criteria, skills, or experience levels you can compromise on to match the salary level instead?

Review the job description

A good job description is the official document used as a reference point for everyone involved and captures all the essential skills and tasks required. It's not a wish list or a job manual. Work with HR when you craft the job description. Your HR partner may provide templates or samples. Use them to capture all key elements of the job to ensure that you and HR and anyone on the hiring team are in alignment. Detail your expectations for the role, including the cultural fit—what does and doesn't work in your team, and why. Evaluate and discuss with HR all requirements, tasks, and responsibilities. For each skill, background, and experience requirement, ask "Why?" Unnecessary requirements confuse priorities, making it harder to find the right person. HR can assist in identifying the essential skills.

Clarify your deal-breakers for candidates with HR as well. If you insist on timely follow-up with clients, high attention to detail, weekly updates on progress, say so. Your HR partner might suggest additional tests or interview questions to help you home in on candidates with the skills and attributes that are most important to you. Keep an open mind and listen to the advice HR shares with you. At this juncture, you'll also discuss possible internal candidates and employee referrals and related policies. Some companies require advertising jobs internally before going to market. Your HR partner will be able to help you identify and reach out to possible internal candidates and ensure that you follow your company's procedures for posting jobs.

These conversations are an opportunity to be frank and to build trust with your HR business partner. If HR is involved in interviewing and selecting candidates, its people need to acutely understand the

right fit for you. Spend the time now so you're both on the same page. Document everything in the job description. If this is a replacement role, ensure that the description aligns with any changes to the job requirements.

Make a plan

You and your HR partner have worked long and hard to think through what you need and how best to position the role. It's time to map out everything in a recruiting and hiring plan. This record doesn't have to be formal or long; your company may use a specific template or form. This is your opportunity to capture your decisions and approach to ensure alignment of goals and expectations. In the plan, specify how many rounds of interviews each candidate will go through, and which people will interview candidates and at what stage. Note all key tasks and timelines and add tips for best practice. For example, if interviews are to occur within a certain time frame (e.g., five days from receipt of résumé) or time from screening to interview (e.g., two days). Block out ample time in your own calendar for screening and interviewing. Consider when you need someone to start. Is there enough time for overlap to arrange a handover? If not, speak with HR about backup and transition plans. Perhaps look to a contractor in the interim or other employees who might view helping out as a growth and learning opportunity.

If concerns crop up during the process, the recruiting and hiring plan acts as your review document. For example, if after one month, you haven't sourced your candidate, instead of a panicked or frustrated conversation, use the plan as your checkpoint and as a tool to navigate a difficult conversation. Where along the process was best practice not followed? "Oh, we took three weeks to process the ad response when we had only committed to one." Reviewing and discussing the plan with your HR partner can help you identify and discuss any issues and work to address them.

Recruit and Screen

Once you've secured all approvals; documented the key skills, abilities, and tasks related to the role and done your homework to understand the package you're offering, you'll work with your HR partner to get your ad in front of job seekers and begin building a pool of candidates.

Write the job ad

A job advertisement is different from a job description. A job description outlines the requirements, whereas the ad *sells* your job. A job ad should outline the main responsibilities and tasks as well as key attractions of the role and organization—the values and culture. Don't dump lists of tasks or monotonous duties into it. Do include items such as training, learning, and career opportunities. HR can assist with writing appropriate copy, including any boilerplate text and avoiding discriminatory language. Ensure that whatever is in the ad is authentic. For example, if you mention that the role is hybrid, be prepared to discuss and explain what that means on your team. If your company process allows you to include the salary band in the ad, prepare to articulate what warrants the higher level as opposed to the lower end. A thoughtful answer to this question will help you establish trust with candidates.

When the language is worked out to everyone's satisfaction, HR can also suggest platforms to use for posting the ad.

Review résumés

Effectively managing the influx of applications requires sharp coordination. Screening should be conducted as soon as résumés are received. Your ideal candidate might be number 84 on the list of résumés, but not accessing them for five days could see them take another role. HR might suggest using AI to help to make screening more efficient and to reduce bias. Work out a process and timeline with HR for receiving screened résumés so you'll have time to review them. If you're responsible for

screening all résumés, allow ample time to sift through them. Use the job description as the basis of your screening questions, ensuring that all candidates tick the main criteria before advancing to the interview round.

Book interviews

Once you screen suitable candidates, schedule their interviews straight away, even as soon as the following day. The allotted time varies according to industry and job level; ideally, however, an interview should be booked as timely and efficiently as possible.

Conduct Interviews

With a pared-down list of candidates, it's time to activate the interview plan you established with HR. Your HR partner can help you coordinate and schedule the people involved in the interview process, ensuring that you follow your established plan, stick to company policies and procedures, and work around everyone's availability within the desired time frame. Of course, the interview is where you'll learn about the candidate's ability to do the job, but it's also a great time to build trust and begin to gather candidate-specific information that will help you make an appropriate offer later on.

Establish or affirm the process

As you engage and activate your hiring panel, your goal is to create value and not erode efficiency. Work with HR to establish a mechanism to receive timely feedback, evaluations, and scorecards from the hiring team. Allow time for discussion of candidate suitability. If multiple people are involved in the decision-making, you'll want to build in extra time for discussions, the increased work required to consolidate the feedback, and the challenge of coordinating competing calendars.

Refine and select questions

Because of the time you invested early on, working with HR to design and select interview questions to draw out candidates' skills, competencies, and cultural fit should be a fairly swift and focused process. Use the updated job description as the basis for questions. HR can advise on how to frame questions, what to look for in the answers, tips to help you probe further, and red flags to watch for.

Talk about money

In the interview, state the salary range of your job up front and ask what the candidate is expecting. Now is the time to test the waters and understand if your expectations are aligned and if not, why. Ask about their current salary and benefits and the last time they received a pay increase. Their salary may already be at the higher level of what you can offer, but if you discover they only recently received the increase, it can help you to position your offering, perhaps with other benefits or a commitment to review the salary at the next performance appraisal.

Ask why they're on the job market

Use the interview to find out why the candidate is leaving their current role. If they're on the market due to a lack of learning and development opportunities at their current company and this is something you can provide, knowing this detail will strengthen your offer. Learning more about what they're looking for is also important for hiring for the long term. Cultural fit matters in attracting the right people, having offers accepted, and ensuring engagement and retention.

Find out who you're up against

In addition to understanding why your candidate is leaving their current position, you'll also want to know where else they're looking. Where else are they interviewing? What roles and salaries are they pursuing? Don't be afraid to ask how the other roles compare to yours—this will help you gauge if you're in the running or not. Find out what stage they're at in the hiring process elsewhere. Say they're at final interview stage at another organization; if you think they're the right candidate, you may want to work with HR and your hiring team to speed up your process to secure them.

Keep in touch

One of the biggest complaints from candidates is the lack of communication and follow-up from hiring managers during the interview process. So work with HR to identify who will communicate with all candidates and how, even if it's only a brief update. Relaying the status and stage of the process is respectful and helps build good relationships. If someone is no longer being considered, let them know as soon as possible.

Make a Choice

After screening and interviewing candidates, you're making your way toward selecting who you'll hire. Often hiring managers relax at this stage, thinking they've found their ideal person. But guess what? Until your candidate has signed a contract, they haven't found their ideal job. And if the recruitment stage requires speed, selection becomes supersonic. HR can help keep you on track and coordinate feedback in this exciting and fast-moving phase of the process.

Wrapup interviews and assessments

Once you've narrowed down the selection, book the second-round interviews with your team as well as any follow-up interviews or testing that might be required. Delays open the door for candidates to interview elsewhere and take other positions.

Gather all feedback

Collate feedback and scorecards from your hiring panel. Discuss your most promising candidates with HR and other stakeholders. This may require additional discussions. If you are fortunate to have a good pool of candidates, it's also prudent to determine who the backup candidate might be.

Consider pre-closing

When you get to a final interview with your selected candidate, you may want to conduct a "pre-close" where you verbally offer the job, barring any last-minute red flags that arise in this final meeting. If things have continued to go well, pose a hypothetical question: If they were offered the role, would they accept? If they say no or they're not sure, ask them what might stop them from accepting the role. If they say yes, you can then present the verbal offer you have prepared with HR.

Make an Offer

At last, you've found your winning candidate! You breathe a sigh of relief. All that needs to be done is to present the offer. But what if they start negotiating, asking for more money or extra benefits or time off before starting? If you feel yourself putting off your answer and becoming a little queasy, you're not alone. I refer to this stage of the recruitment process as the pointy end. You don't want to stall, relax, or falter. You need to switch it up a gear. The rapport, relationship, and trust you've worked to establish during the process are key in getting offers across the line. With the right preparation and assistance from HR, presenting and negotiating the offer can be a breeze.

Understand what's involved in an offer

An offer is the compensation package, including salary and benefits, that you present to your candidate. There are generally two stages. First there is the verbal offer, where you state your intention to hire the person and name the salary details, either face-to-face or over a phone or video call. This generally happens in the final interview or within the following one to three days. The formal offer, generally a letter and contract detailing the salary and benefits and timeline, follows the verbal offer and is usually delivered by email, post, or courier. The optimal timeline for the formal offer is one to two days after you've presented the verbal offer, although the same day is ideal.

Keep HR in the loop

Even though you've been in touch with HR throughout the whole hiring process, the formal offer of the contract can still take time to generate. If this comes from your HR team, advise them as soon as you have decided on your candidate and let them know that you intend to make a verbal offer.

Present the offer

It's best practice for the offer to be made by you, the manager, since you've been involved from the start. By the time you get to the decision and offer stage, you have built the foundation for a relationship with your future employee. Plus, you've been in conversations, listening deeply to capture the precious nuggets of information that might help tailor and influence the offer. For example, if your candidate mentioned an area of training that was of interest to them, you could investigate the course ahead of time and be able to describe how your company could support it financially or otherwise.

The first offer should be verbal and strong. A talent-tight market is not one in which to lowball, whether it's happening as a pre-close in a final interview or as a follow-up after all interview rounds have been completed. Your HR team can help you prepare for this conversation, but you might open by saying, "I am delighted to offer you the role with us; the salary is XXX." Be warm and enthusiastic. Share why you're looking forward to working with them. Inquire if they have any questions.

Ask for a verbal acceptance

Once you've delivered the verbal offer, ask if they're happy to accept based on the details you've provided. This is yet another pre-close: "Are you happy to accept?" You're looking for an affirmation. Responses such as, "I'd like to take a few days to think it over" should sound alarm bells for you and prompt you to try to learn more.

Probe for more details

If your candidate asks for time to think your offer over, ask what areas require consideration. If they remain steadfast, use your judgment. Sometimes people really do need more time. If that's the case, applying pressure won't assist and might turn them away. However, if you're concerned the offer won't be accepted, you may want to revert to your backup plan, keeping HR in the loop. If the candidate mentioned in the interview process that they were exploring other job opportunities, ask again where they are in process with those companies and who they're waiting to hear back from. Ask if they will be turning down other offers. You want to hear yes, of course. These might seem uncomfortable questions to ask, but they're necessary. Don't stick your head in the sand, hoping all will be OK. It's better to know because it will give you time to counter other offers and negotiate a successful offer.

Negotiate terms—or not

Sometimes candidates will want to negotiate. Put yourself in their shoes and consider their viewpoint and motivations. You have done the work to prepare, so you know how far you can go with the salary, what the market is like, and the value of your potential new hire.

Sometimes, it's better to stick with what you believe is the right and fair original offer, especially if it was a strong one. If you're pushing back, do so in a way that makes your potential new hire feel OK

for asking. It takes courage to talk about money and negotiate. You want any employee to feel comfortable to come to you for any matter in the future. Acknowledge the request, thank them for being open with you, and either share the reason you can't deliver what they have asked for or, if you believe what they are asking for is fair, agree. When discussing these points, be sure to mention the additional benefits that may be offered—such as free lunches, flexible hours, seasonal bonuses, training, and so on—that may be as attractive as a higher salary.

Update HR

After you've reached a verbal agreement, share the details with HR so they can generate the official letter and contract.

Check references

With your verbal agreement on the terms of the job, get your candidate's permission to conduct reference checks. It's no longer best practice to check the references of multiple candidates. It's time-consuming and inefficient. The process can be outsourced to an external body or performed by HR or yourself, but I recommend that managers conduct these themselves, as it can provide additional insights into new hires. All reference checks should be completed as soon as possible and before the formal contract and letter of offer are issued. If references cannot be completed straight away, this may delay finalizing and delivering the contract, so keep your candidate up to date.

Close the Deal

The recruitment process isn't over until your person starts!

Deliver the official offer and contract

Once references are completed, send the contract and letter of offer. These constitute the official offer, outlining the necessary information and legalities. Typically, these documents are generated by HR and can be sent via HR or you as hiring manager. I suggest they come from you, with a phone call advising that the package is on its way. Ideally, the contract should go out the same day as the verbal offer, but sometimes there are delays in securing references so update your candidate as necessary.

Address last-minute negotiations

Even when the offer is set in ink, candidates will sometimes try to negotiate more money or make other changes. You have the salary banding and market information you gathered earlier in the process, so you know what is reasonable to negotiate. For contract changes, HR will know what is and isn't possible. Generally, HR will oversee the signing and take over the documentation from there.

Stay in touch

Keep in regular contact with your new hire even after the contract has been signed and returned during their notice period, including if they're taking additional time before starting. They may continue to receive recruitment calls even if they've stopped actively applying. Additionally, if they're good at what they do, expect their existing employer to try and convince them to stay, right up until the last minute. This is why building a relationship with your candidate and keeping in touch are keys to successfully signing your chosen candidate and seeing them start in their new role.

What If Your Search Doesn't Yield a Final Candidate?

Sometimes a search can wind down without finding the right person. If this happens, look to the backup plan you created with HR for an interim solution. Review the documented process plan for learning

opportunities. Recruitment is not easy; even undertaken with the best of skills and intentions, it can go awry. Determine if you start again with a different plan, or consider engaging an expert recruiter. Working with a recruitment agency is not a concession of failure but a strategic enhancement of the hiring process. It reflects a commitment to securing the best talent through all available means. Leveraging the unique skills, networks, and insights of recruitment agencies can transform a challenging hiring process into a success story.

Gone are the days of making a job offer and simply having it accepted. Working with HR to scope, recruit, and hire for your team is a delicate and complex dance. Thorough preparation, effective communication, and collaborative partnership will help you identify and hire the candidate whose skills and abilities will move your team and your organization forward.

Roxanne Calder, author of *Employable: 7 Attributes to Assure Your Working Future* (Major Street, 2022), is the founder and managing director of EST10—one of Sydney’s most successful recruitment agencies. For more information on how Roxanne can assist with your recruitment needs, visit www.est10.com.au.

CHAPTER 6

Reduce Personal Bias in the Hiring Process

by Ruchika T. Malhotra

When it comes to hiring candidates from underestimated backgrounds, good intentions do not necessarily lead to good results. I once met a talent acquisition leader at a large global technology company who had changed the organization's hiring process in multiple ways to bring in more candidates of color but was frustrated by the lack of progress. Internal analyses showed that even though the company had interviewed a higher number of non-white candidates in preliminary rounds, their final hires were still overwhelmingly white.

I've seen this same situation play out in multiple organizations and industries, and often it's because well-intentioned hiring managers end up inadvertently weeding out qualified candidates from underestimated backgrounds because of bias.

Changes in process and diversity initiatives alone are not going to remedy the lack of equal representation in companies. Individual managers who are often making the final hiring decisions need to address their own bias.

But how? In my experience, there are several things you, as a hiring manager, can do.

Before taking any steps, however, it's important to accept that no one is preloaded with inclusive behavior; we are, in fact, biologically hardwired to align with people like us and reject those whom we consider different.

Undoing these behaviors requires moving from a fixed mindset—the belief that we're already doing the best we possibly can to build diverse teams—to one of openness and growth, where we can deeply understand, challenge, and confront our personal biases.

Here are the specific strategies I recommend.

Accept that you have biases, especially affinity bias

Even if you head up your organization's diversity committee, even if you are from an underrepresented community, you have biases that impact your professional decisions, especially hiring. *Affinity bias*—having a more favorable opinion of someone like us—is one of the most common.¹ In hiring, this often means referring or selecting a candidate who shares our race or gender, or who went to the same school, speaks the same language, or reminds us of our younger selves.

Microsoft's corporate vice president of HR, Chuck Edward, told me that affinity bias is widespread in hiring and often leads people to seek out and hire candidates who “look, act, and operate” like them. He admits falling into this trap himself. “I’ve had to be very careful to address it head on,” he says.

Create a personal learning list

Spend time reading and learning about the experience of underrepresented communities at work. Among the books I recommend are *So You Want to Talk About Race* by Ijeoma Oluo, *White Fragility* by Robin

DiAngelo, and *What Works* by Iris Bohnet.² I've found Harvard Business Review's *Women at Work* podcast to be an excellent resource as well.

Seek out resources that you wouldn't normally come across and look for books and articles from underrepresented communities. In the United States, that might mean books that include the perspectives of immigrants, people with disabilities, and native American and Indigenous communities.

Not only will this activity help you uncover the biases you're bringing to hiring decisions, it will also equip you with the framework and language to recognize, and possibly call out, bias in your company's processes.

Ask: "Where is bias showing up in this decision, or where could it?"

One team I work with had hiring managers who would often flippantly say things like: "This candidate is qualified, but really isn't a cultural fit." Or "We should hire *this* person. I could easily see myself having a beer with them after work."

These comments, laden with bias, would go unchecked. When the leadership team, which was entirely male and white, asked for my help in creating guidelines to reduce bias in the hiring processes, I suggested they start candidate debrief meetings by asking, "Where could bias show up in our decisions today?" This intervention, along with other process changes, led the team to hire two women leaders.

Explicitly acknowledging that we all have biases, especially unconsciously, and creating a space to call them out forges an opportunity to hold ourselves and each other accountable.

Reduce the influence of your peers' opinions on your hiring decisions

In the past, Microsoft would allow hiring managers to see each other's feedback on a candidate before it was their turn to interview them. "Everybody on the interview loop could see what others were," says Edward. "It's very clear how that could lead to biases and being influenced by someone else's views."

Recently, the company made the feedback loop private—a hiring manager can't log in to the tool and see their colleagues' feedback until they've entered their own assessment. Edward says that the change has allowed people the freedom to form their own opinions without being influenced by their peers—or their bosses.

Even if you don't use a software tool for hiring loops, refrain from comparing notes verbally until you have formed your own point of view. I recommend writing down your feedback and whether you're inclined to hire the candidate before you debrief with your colleagues. Again, ask yourself as you're writing: "How could bias have impacted my assessment and recommendation?"

Use a "flip it to test" approach

In 2017, *Fortune* 500 executive Kristen Pressner gave a brave TEDx Talk, where she admitted to harboring gender bias against women leaders, despite identifying as a woman herself. Pressner developed a technique to disrupt bias: Ask yourself, if you were to swap out the candidate from a historically unseen background with one of your more typical hires, would you have the same reaction? For example, if a woman of color candidate speaks passionately, and you're less inclined to hire her because you think of her as "angry," would you use the same word if a white man spoke the same way?

"Flip it to test it" is a relatively easy way to call out bias as it happens. In a recent hiring decision that I was part of, a highly qualified woman of color was approached to apply formally for a role for which she was already informally performing the duties. Since the organization was already familiar with her work and performance, the hiring manager saw no harm in having her skip the early parts of the hiring process. But some colleagues expressed concern about "bending the rules" for her. During the discussion, I flipped the concern by asking two questions: "Would we have the same reservations if we were circumventing the traditional hiring process for a white person?" and "In the past, when all the candidates we were considering were white men, did we focus extensively on the fairness of the hiring process?" In both cases, the hiring committee unanimously answered no. We were able to recognize our bias and eventually made an offer to the candidate.

Understand how reducing bias could personally benefit you

Diversity in our workplace makes us smarter, more innovative, and promotes better critical thinking.³ It's not only the organization that benefits; we personally have a lot to gain by working with people from all different backgrounds. By recognizing how we benefit from reducing our own bias—rather than focusing on the ROI for the company—we're likely to be more motivated to take action.

As Michelle Gadsen-Williams, managing director and global head of diversity, equity, and inclusion at BlackRock, told me, "A culture of equality is a multiplier. We can't achieve a culture of equality if personal unconscious bias is not addressed first and foremost."

Author's note (7/16/20): I updated the language in this article because I am no longer using "diverse" to refer to a person or people. When we categorize people of color or women as "diverse," we are centering white people and men as the accepted norm. I also updated "unconscious bias" to simply be "bias."

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THREE BEHAVIORAL NUDGES TO REDUCE BIAS IN HIRING

by Paola Cecchi-Dimeglio

Everyone who has worked to get diversity right knows there is no elixir that increases diverse talent. Doing DEI by the numbers just won't get you there. But here's some good news: By focusing on decision intelligence and evidence-based solutions that drive scalable change and boost inclusion, leaders *can* increase the number of diverse candidates that they hire.^a

As an academic, I've long studied the problem of increasing employee diversity in companies; and as a consultant, I've applied what I've learned to help companies hire and promote more fairly. Through this work, I've identified a few behavioral nudges that together form an effective, well-rounded approach—one that can help executives make better, less-biased decisions in hiring.

Generate ranked criteria for candidates

Recruitment can be overwhelming for both interviewers and candidates, but a strategic approach can help bring order to the process. According to decision research, having a solid list of predetermined, prioritized qualifications for a position is key to choosing wisely.^b The hiring committee should agree on five to 10 qualifications, which may span both technical skills and business acumen, and rank them by importance.

During interviews, the goal is for each qualification and candidate to stand on their own, to shield any assessment from prior influences. After the interview, the interviewer can assign a high, medium, or low rating. For example, in hiring for a communications manager, writing and collaboration might be ranked as the two top skills necessary, while web design might be ranked as fifth or sixth. Then, when assessing the group of candidates, those who scored high on more important factors would end up ranked higher than those who scored high on less-prioritized qualifications, thus surfacing those candidates who exhibited the

most important skills for the job. This practice forces assessors to focus separately on each area and score it individually, as opposed to, say, judging the interview to be a total success based on one or two positive elements that may or may not be core to the job.

Creating clear, succinct lists of qualifications provides a set of focal points that can steer decision makers away from race, gender, and socioeconomic background. This strategy should generate diverse sets of options and can be used with a broad range of position types.

Challenge yourself to support the opposite opinion

First interviewed, first hired. Research reveals a tendency to favor early options and undervalue contradictory evidence that comes later.^c In other words, if you've made an initial judgment, you are more likely to ignore or discount new data that doesn't support it.

An HR professional at a global professional services firm I worked with noticed that 89% of new hires were the first candidates seen. The committee wanted to counter this biasing tendency, so decision makers applied a "thinking of the opposite" strategy. For each candidate who had been favored, the decision makers were challenged to think of reasons why these top candidates might be the *wrong* choice. Similarly, for the candidates who were not ranked highly, decision makers were challenged to develop an argument for why they might be the *right* fit. When challenged to create the necessary counterarguments, decision makers may go back and refer to data that they initially discounted, ultimately making their decisions more informed and objective.

Modify the environment

Different environments can improve or support high-quality decision-making and impact organizations' hiring efforts. Seemingly small factors such as time slots, room arrangements, and room temperature can all exert influence on the decision-making process.

We can all be choice architects. Choice architecture refers to the way alternatives are presented to decision-makers. For example, one design choice is timing: If you ask someone to rate a candidate before lunch, when they're hungry, their ratings are likely to be harsher.^d However, if you ask them to do it at a time of day when people tend to have more brainpower and are more relaxed—for example, in the morning—their ratings are likely to be more favorable.

Shifting interview times is one way to use psychological principles to influence behavior for good, so create blocks of time in your calendar when you predict you will be feeling more relaxed and energetic, and allocate that time to rate candidates. To be even more confident in your decision, make an initial decision early in the week and revisit it toward the end of the week. At that point, ask yourself: *Has your thinking evolved, or do you still feel the same way about the decision?*

^a Bruce Posner, "Why You Decide the Way You Do," *MIT Sloan Management Review*, December 16, 2014, <https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/why-you-decide-the-way-you-do/>.

^b Ralph L. Keeney, "Value-Focused Brainstorming," *Decision Analysis* 9, no. 4 (December 1, 2012): 303–313, <https://doi.org/10.1287/deca.1120.0251>.

^c Asher Koriati, Sarah Lichtenstein, and Baruch Fischhoff, "Reasons for Confidence," *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Learning and Memory* 6, no. 2 (1980): 107–118, <https://doi.org/10.1037/0278-7393.6.2.107>.

^d Shai Danziger, Jonathan Levav, and Liora Avnaim-Pesso, "Extraneous Factors in Judicial Decisions," *PNAS* 108, no. 17 (2011): 6889–6892, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1018033108>.

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Adapted from “6 Behavioral Nudges to Reduce Bias in Hiring and Promotions” on hbr.org, November 2, 2022 (product #H07BP0).

Adapted from “How to Reduce Personal Bias When Hiring” on hbr.org, June 28, 2019 (product #H05105).

NOTES

1. Helen Turnbull, PhD, “The Affinity Bias Conundrum: The Illusion of Inclusion—Part III” *Diversity Journal*, May 20, 2014, <https://diversityjournal.com/13763-affinity-bias-conundrum-illusion-inclusion-part-iii/>.

2. Ijeoma Oluo, *So You Want to Talk About Race* (New York: Seal Press, 2018); Robin J. DiAngelo, *White Fragility: Why It’s So Hard for White People to Talk About Racism* (Boston: Beacon Press, 2018); Iris Bohnet, *What Works: Gender Equality by Design* (Cambridge, MA: The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2016).

3. Katherine W. Phillips, “How Diversity Makes Us Smarter,” *Greater Good Magazine*, September 18, 2017, https://greatergood.berkeley.edu/article/item/how_diversity_makes_us_smarter.